TOWARD ETHICAL OPEN DATA: STRENGTHENING INFORMED CONSENT PRACTICES IN PSYCHOLOGICAL RESEARCH

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BACKGROUND & RESEARCH AIM

- The open science movement has renewed attention to ethical issues surrounding informed consent, particularly for data sharing.
- APA guidelines (APA, 7th edition) recommend informing participants about the potential future reuse of their data.
- However, this practice remains inconsistently addressed in psychological research.

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THIS STUDY EXAMINES HOW INFORMED CONSENT FOR DATA SHARING IS PROMOTED IN PSYCHOLOGY, BY MAPPING:

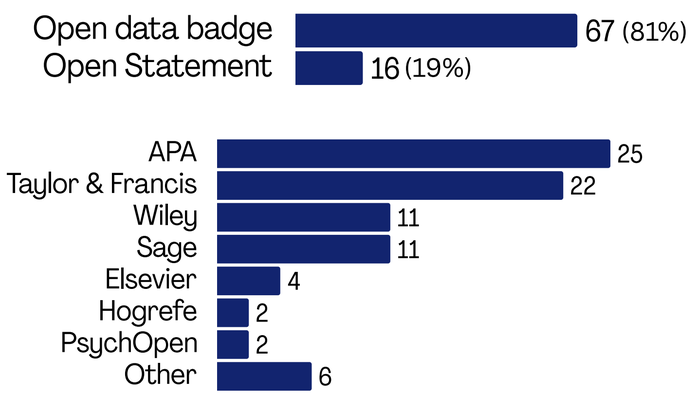
JOURNAL GUIDELINES | **RESEARCHERS' PRACTICES**

METHOD

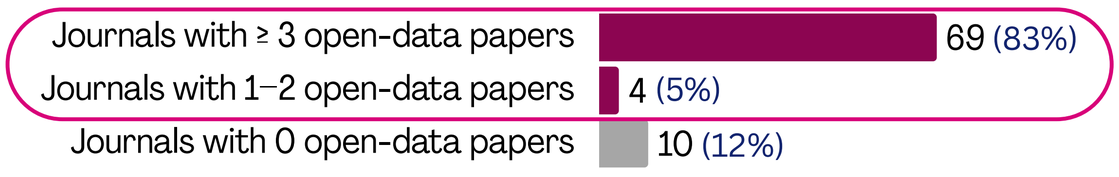
Data-sharing guidelines were reviewed from OSF-listed journals classified in the psychology field that award the Open Data Badge.

83 journals

Eighty-three psychology **journals** promoting open data practices were identified.



Three open-data articles (2024–2025) from each journal were identified.



213 papers

Empirical studies with human participants were selected to synthesize how participant informed consent was reported.

196 papers

Exclusion criteria:
- Non empirical data (simulation)
- Systematic review/meta analysis
- No human participants
- Archivial data/secondary data

Screening:
Manuscript
Supplemental
OSF

RESULTS

THREE LEVELS OF DATA-SHARING AWARENESS IN JOURNALS

55 (66%) — **NO GUIDELINES ON INFORMED CONSENT FOR DATA SHARING**

24 (29%) — **INFORMED CONSENT NEEDED FOR SHARING SENSITIVE OR IDENTIFIABLE DATA**

4 (5%) — **INFORMED CONSENT NEEDED FOR SECONDARY USE OF DATA**

> *The method section also must include a statement describing how informed consent was obtained from the participants (or their parents/guardians), **including for secondary use of data if applicable.***

No journal provided explicit guidelines on the need for obtaining informed consent for sharing data on open platforms that will be used by other researchers.

FOUR LEVELS OF DATA-SHARING AWARENESS IN PAPERS

53 (27%) — **NO INFORMATION ON INFORMED CONSENT**

132 (67%) — **MINIMAL CONSENT REPORTING**

> *Informed written consent was obtained from all participants*

4 (2%) — **DETAILED CONSENT REPORTING BUT NOT FOR DATA SHARING**

7 (4%) — **EXPLICIT CONSENT FOR DATA SHARING**

Information on data reuse was reported in the informed consent
6 papers

Croke & Smiley, 2025
Keller et al., 2025
Keller et al., 2025
Neville et al., 2025
Phillips et al., 2025
Spitzer et al., 2024

Required a separate consent for data sharing
1 paper

Kershaw, 2025

WHAT CAN WE DO TO PROMOTE AN ETHICAL DATA SHARING?

EDITORS AND PUBLISHERS

- Provide up-to-date, easily accessible **GUIDELINES** on ethical issues related to data sharing.
- **REQUIRE** evidence of **informed consent for data sharing**, when appropriate, as a criterion for awarding Open Data badge or other forms of open data recognition.
- Provide editorial **INCENTIVES** for ethical data sharing (e.g., APC discounts or dedicated visibility initiatives such as Article Spotlight) to promote responsible open science practices.

RESEARCHERS

- **Informing** participants about data sharing practices before asking the consent.
- Require explicit **consent for data sharing** to participants.
- Share the informed consent and information sheet as part of **open research materials** (e.g., on OSF).

How to verify that participants understood the implications of open data sharing before giving their consent?

RN IT Italian Reproducibility Network